away on holiday until 2 October and the Director General of Military Operations was on a cruise on an Indian aircraft carrier.[84]

Why, though, did India lose the war so categorically? Indian military preparations and responses to China's attack have been widely analysed and criticized. When the official military inquiry into the 1962 debacle, the Henderson-Brooks report, is finally released, it will give us an even fuller account of Delhi's thoughts and actions. However, it is clear enough that Indian forces were not numerically inferior in overall terms. Getting precise figures is difficult, at least in part because of the 'accounting system' of the two armies: the size of corps, divisions, brigades, and other units, in terms of which most histories of the war are rendered, are not equivalent. An American estimate, by Larry M. Wortzel of the US Army War College, is that at the start of the war India had about 16,000 troops while the Chinese had about 10,000 troops in the east. In the west, the two sides were about level in terms of numbers: India had about 6000 troops while China had about 6300 troops. By the second half of the war, from 14 November onward, India had 22,000 troops whereas the Chinese had 25,000 troops in the east. In the west, India had increased its forces to 15,000 troops. Wortzel does not provide a final figure for Chinese deployments in the western sector – we can assume that, as in the east, the two forces were roughly in balance numerically.[85]

In the Indian popular imagination, there is a view of its forces being overrun by hordes of Chinese troops. When Indian deployments were overrun it was not because of the overall balance of military forces in the two sectors. It was because the Chinese had concentrated forces and achieved local dominance. Where India statically defended border posts, the Chinese were highly mobile and chose where and when to fight – which they had mastered in the civil war and against the Japanese. Tactics mattered too. The Chinese laid down barrages of fire to pin the Indian forces and soften up positions, attacked the flanks, and initiated battle at night if necessary. They also had better reconnaissance and ground intelligence, robust infrastructure leading to the front, and superior equipment including high-altitude winter clothing (while Indian troops